impacted India's nuclear weapon capabilities, it had been unsuccessful in putting a complete stop to it. The mutual desire of India and America to reset their relations post-Pokhran, which gained in momentum under the Presidency of George W. Bush, provided India with a fresh opportunity to break out of the nuclear sanctions. The NSG guidelines had crippled India's nuclear energy programme, and with the looming climate change crisis threatening to 'outlaw' coal, the need for clean energy gained priority.

The opportunity presented itself when Prime Minister Dr Manmohan Singh made an official visit to Washington in July 2005 and, with President Bush, announced their intention to enter into a nuclear energy agreement. The following March (2006), during President Bush's return visit, the two sides reached an agreement on a separation plan that made bilateral civil nuclear cooperation, and nuclear trade for India with the rest of the world, a real possibility for the first time in three decades.

After the end of the Cold War, other important changes were also taking place in the global nuclear landscape. America had led a global initiative to destroy nuclear weapons in the possession of successor states of the Soviet Union (other than the Russian Federation); more nuclear weapon states had emerged—Pakistan and North Korea; while still others, like Iraq, Libya and Iran, were suspected of having active nuclear weapons programmes. Non-proliferation was a raison d'être for the Americans to invade Iraq. And China had come out of the nuclear cold, finally joining the NPT in 1992 and the NSG in 2005. The NSG membership had expanded to 47 countries (from the initial seven). The expanded membership of the NSG was a sign of growing international concerns over the possible proliferation of nuclear weapons and technology. In this context, the Indo–US nuclear deal was seen in some quarters as